

Formora: where it stands, what’s next, and the long-term plan

For the owner and for any coding agent (Codex, Claude Code) continuing the work. It records what was built and when, what works and what doesn’t, what to do next in order, and a plan for the next 18 months. The short version for agents is `AGENTS.md` in the repository.

49 templates (46 studio, 41 approved)	156 job titles with sample content	8 database migrations	15 end-to-end test suites	32 commits on the branch
--	---------------------------------------	--------------------------	------------------------------	-----------------------------

1 · What the product is

A portfolio and personal-website builder for every profession, not only designers and developers. People choose a design drawn for their job, fill it by clicking text in a live preview (or import a CV, LinkedIn export or GitHub, or ask the AI assistant), and publish at `/p/address` or on their own domain, bought or connected in the editor with HTTPS set up automatically. A Pro blog, ratings, a community board, support desk and automatic “suggested updates” complete it.

Business model. 14-day free trial with everything in Pro, then Basic \$10/yr, Pro \$24/yr, Premium \$49/yr (a domain included). AI help is paid separately (credits or the customer’s own Anthropic key). Domains are resold at registrar price plus markup. The newest piece is a **free template gallery** as content marketing: every design downloads free (MIT), and customising without code, hosting, domains and blogs are what people pay for.

2 · Chronology

DATE	WHAT HAPPENED
24 Jul 2026	Repository started: ideas and a folder for ready-made templates.
30 Sep	First build: portfolio editor, three original templates, Google sign-in, database workflow.
2 Oct · 1	Foundations. Production build fixed; account saving, publishing, AI copy editing; business plan and setup docs; custom domains and profile import (GitHub, LinkedIn export, CV, Claude); hardened database layer; serving portfolios and customer domains from our own server (Caddy on-demand TLS).
2 Oct · 2	Design and community. New landing page, header, footer and type system; community board (suggestions, reviews, designs, moderation); chooser, preview, sign-in and account pages redesigned.
2 Oct · 3	Studio templates. Shared content model and kit; 35 hand-made designs across developer, design, art, photography, writing, architecture, research, data, marketing, consulting, music, film, leadership, student and wellness work; studio editor with click-to-edit, image uploads; gallery filters; owner approval desk.
2 Oct · 4	Money. Plans, trial and grace period, credits and own API keys, Stripe checkout and renewals, lifecycle emails, research agent, support desk, pricing and about pages, hourly jobs container.

2 Oct · 5	Everyday professions. 15 templates for law, real estate, healthcare, education, finance, trades, food, beauty, sales, engineering, non-profits; owner's two rounds of review decisions (4 then 9 templates rejected and removed); 156 job titles with sample content written for each, a "What do you do?" finder and SEO pages per job.
2 Oct · 6	Moving templates. Residence, Margin Notes, Pulse, Counsel and Mise, with scroll-driven motion and reduced-motion fallbacks (awaiting approval).
2 Oct · 7	Launch readiness. Previews always show a loading state; star ratings ("No ratings yet" at zero); Journal with an admin editor; customer blogs (now Pro-only) on <code>/p/.../blog</code> and custom domains; domain expiry and renewals; <code>/admin</code> go-live checklist; local test login; local and launch guides.
2 Oct · 8	Editing sweep. Every template checked: every clickable spot opens its field, edits save to the database and survive reloads. Fixed photo click-to-edit, missing sections and missing names/headings in several templates.
2 Oct · 9	Gallery. Free template gallery with tilting video tiles and search; an article page per design; free ZIP downloads that run on their own; clips for all 46 designs; community template submissions with automatic ZIP checks and manual review; email + password accounts with date of birth (16+), verification and password reset; usernames.
2 Oct · 10	Handoff. Tests moved into the repository (<code>tests/e2e</code>), <code>AGENTS.md</code> rewritten for coding agents, this document.

3 · Progress by area

AREA	STATUS	NOTES
Editor and saving	Done	Click-to-edit, lists, images, palettes, fonts, undo, autosave to account with conflict handling, sample content per job title.
Templates	Done	46 studio + 3 originals. 41 studio approved; 5 moving ones pending. Originals use an older editor (no blog, no gallery download).
Publishing	Done	/p/address , snapshot on publish, resting page when a plan lapses, plan limits on live portfolios.
Custom domains	Done	Connect (DNS checks + TXT proof) and buy (Stripe → registrar), HTTPS via Caddy, renewals with reminders. Registrar renew endpoint not verified against live Vercel docs (falls back to manual).
Accounts	Done	Google, email + password (script, verification, reset, 16+), usernames, local test login.
Billing	Done	Plans, trial/grace, renewals, credits, own API key, receipts. Tested with Stripe mocks only.
AI	Done	Assistant, imports, research agent; metered with credits and a daily budget cap.
Auto-updates	Partly	GitHub weekly and research on a fixed schedule; not configurable yet (plan in the auto-update PDF).
Blogs	Done	Journal (admin) and customer blogs (Pro). No “Blog” link in template menus yet.
Gallery and free downloads	Done	Tiles, search, articles, ratings, downloads, submissions, review.
Community and support	Done	Moderation, spam rules, support tickets with email replies.
Admin	Done	Go-live checklist, template approvals, Journal, gallery review, moderation, support.
Analytics	Not started	No visitor, sign-up or conversion tracking yet. Needed before spending on ads.
Production launch	Not started	Needs a domain, a VPS, Google sign-in keys, Stripe live keys, SMTP. Steps in docs/LAUNCH.md .

4 · Known gaps and risks (honest list)

ISSUE	IMPACT	WHAT TO DO
Everything runs on one server, and images, uploads and gallery ZIPs are stored in PostgreSQL	Fine for thousands of users; the database grows with media and backups get slower	Move media to object storage (Cloudflare R2 or S3) once the database passes ~5 GB
Rate limits are kept in memory	Reset on restart; won’t work across several servers	Move to Postgres or Redis when adding a second server
Registrar renew call written without access to Vercel’s docs	A renewal could fail	Verify before the first renewals (a year after launch); a failure keeps the payment and emails you to renew by hand

Emails need SMTP in production	Without it, password accounts can't verify or reset	Set SMTP before launch (the <code>/admin</code> checklist shows it)
LinkedIn, Facebook and personal Instagram give no API for profile data	Auto-update can't read them	Upload/export reminders; business Instagram and YouTube via official APIs and feeds
Gallery clips (~20 MB) are committed to git	Repository grows each time clips are re-recorded	Fine for now; move to object storage with the other media
Older files fail lint (legacy pages)	Noise in <code>npm run lint</code>	Clean up gradually; don't add new errors
Low prices (\$10/yr) vs. ad costs	Paid ads would lose money per customer	Launch with free channels; test a "done for you" offer and higher prices
Brand name undecided	Domain, logo and copy depend on it	Decide before buying the domain; the name lives mostly in <code>lib/brand.ts</code>

5 · To-do, in order

FOR THE OWNER (DECISIONS AND ACCOUNTS)

1. Pick the brand name and buy the `.com` (Cloudflare or Porkbun). Do a quick trademark search first.
2. Approve or reject the five moving templates at `/templates/review`.
3. Answer the five auto-update questions (plan limits, auto-apply, auto-publish, sources, daily checks for Pro), or say “use your recommendations”.
4. Decide pricing (current, or higher plus a “done for you” offer) and the free-template licence (MIT, or credit required).
5. Create accounts: Hetzner (or DigitalOcean) server, Google Cloud OAuth client, Stripe (live), a business mailbox with SMTP, Vercel (only if selling domains), Anthropic (for AI).

FOR THE NEXT CODING SESSIONS

#	TASK	DONE WHEN	EFFORT
1	Rename the brand if decided	<code>lib/brand.ts</code> , metadata, emails, docs and the MIT notice use the new name; build and tests pass	2–3 h
2	Privacy-friendly analytics (self-hosted Umami or Plausible) and conversion events	Visits, sign-ups, publishes, downloads and payments visible in one dashboard; no cookies banner needed	½ day
3	Configurable auto-update, phase 1	Per-customer sources and frequency within plan limits; <code>/admin/updates</code> ; run history; failure handling (see auto-update PDF)	1–2 days
4	“Done for you” order	A paid checkout (e.g. £49–99) that creates a support ticket with the customer’s materials; admin can deliver into their account	1 day
5	Blog link in template menus; blog and downloads for the three original templates	A “Blog” link appears when a site has posts; originals behave like studio templates	1 day
6	Launch on the VPS following <code>docs/LAUNCH.md</code>	<code>/admin</code> checklist green; a real payment and refund done; a test domain connected with HTTPS	½–1 day
7	Auto-update phase 2: RSS/blog, Medium, Substack, YouTube, ORCID; auto-apply safe updates with undo	New sources tested with mocks; owners can undo for 30 days	1–2 days
8	“Update my site from Claude or ChatGPT”: an MCP connector with OAuth	A customer adds the connector and can read and update their portfolio by chat, with changes saved as drafts	2–3 days
9	Move media to object storage	New uploads, gallery ZIPs and clips go to R2/S3; old ones migrated; database size drops	1 day

6 · Long-term plan (18 months)

WEEKS 0–2 · LAUNCH

Go live and prove the basics work for strangers

- Domain, VPS, live keys, SMTP, analytics; approve templates; publish 5–10 Journal articles.
- Make 5 real portfolios free for friends or local businesses (proof and examples).
- Submit the sitemap to Google Search Console; the 156 job-title pages and 40+ gallery pages are the main free traffic source.

Target: 50 sign-ups, 10 published sites, first paying customer.

MONTHS 1–3 · FIRST USERS

Find which jobs respond, and the first revenue

- Direct outreach to local professionals without websites (Google Maps), with a done-for-you offer: the fastest route to revenue.
- Launch posts: Show HN, Indie Hackers, Product Hunt, r/SideProject; a LinkedIn build-in-public series.
- Small ad tests (£50–100) on one or two job titles, measured with analytics; keep only what pays back.
- Ship configurable auto-update (phases 1–2) and the done-for-you checkout.

Target: 300 sign-ups, 40 paying, first community template in the gallery.

MONTHS 3–6 · PRODUCT–MARKET FIT

Double down on the professions that pay

- Pick 2–3 professions with the best conversion (likely regulated or local service jobs: solicitors, therapists, tradespeople, estate agents) and make the best product for them: more templates, profession-specific sections (registration numbers, booking links, reviews), guides and SEO pages.
- Gallery as a growth loop: invite designers to submit; feature them; share downloads on social.
- MCP connector so people update their site from Claude or ChatGPT; Instagram business and Google reviews (after platform approvals).
- Revisit pricing with real data; consider monthly billing.

Target: 150 paying customers, under 5% monthly churn, a repeatable channel with known cost per customer.

Scale the channel that works

- Partnerships: professional bodies, bootcamps, coworking spaces, accountants who serve sole traders; team plans for small practices (one bill, several portfolios).
- Affiliate or referral credits for customers and template designers.
- Technical: object storage and a CDN for media; managed PostgreSQL with point-in-time backups; job queue for updates and emails; second app server behind the load balancer once traffic needs it.

Target: 1,000 paying customers; infrastructure under 10% of revenue.

From website builder to a professional's online presence

- Booking and enquiries built in (calendar, contact forms with spam protection, simple CRM).
- A paid template marketplace alongside the free gallery, sharing revenue with designers.
- Agency and white-label plans for people who build sites for clients.
- Localisation (languages and currencies) for the best-performing countries.

Target: sustainable profit, a recognised name in two or three professions.

TECHNICAL SCALING CHECKPOINTS

WHEN	CHANGE
Database > 5 GB or backups slow	Media to object storage (R2/S3) behind a CDN
CPU regularly > 60% or > 50k visits/day	Bigger server first; then a second app server, shared rate limits (Redis), sessions already stateless (JWT)
> 1,000 paying customers	Managed PostgreSQL with point-in-time recovery; uptime monitoring and alerts; status page
Hourly jobs take > 10 minutes	Job queue with workers (updates, emails, renewals)
Selling in the EU/UK at scale	VAT handling (Stripe Tax), data-processing agreement, cookie-free analytics kept

7 · Where to find things

AGENTS.md	Rules, map and conventions for coding agents
docs/LOCAL.md	Run it on a laptop with a test account
docs/LAUNCH.md	Hosting choice, server setup, customers' own domains
docs/GALLERY.md	Free downloads, clips, submissions and review
docs/TEMPLATES.md	Every template and how to add one
docs/BUSINESS_PLAN.md	Positioning, pricing and unit economics
docs/plans/laptop-setup-and-auto-update-plan.pdf	Laptop setup and the configurable auto-update plan
tests/e2e/README.md	How to run the end-to-end tests